

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 3

Introduction to the Ism

1. Connection with the previous lesson

Words come into being through the joining of letters and *harakaat*. *Lafz* is of two kinds: meaningful and meaningless. The meaningless is called *Muhmal* and the meaningful is called *Kalimah*. Every word in the Qur'an is a *Kalimah*, that is, meaningful.

The categories of Lafz	
meaningful → <i>Kalimah</i>	meaningless → <i>Muhmal</i>

The categories of <i>Kalimah</i>		
<i>Ism</i>	<i>Fi'l</i>	<i>Harf</i>

A notable difference: English has nine parts of speech, whereas Arabic grammar has only three. This is what makes the Arabic division simpler and more orderly.

2. The definition of *Ism*

The literal meaning of *Ism* is *name*. The name of any person, thing, place, quality or action is an *Ism*.

In terminology, an *Ism* is a *Kalimah* that conveys its meaning without joining another *Kalimah*, and in which none of the three tenses — past, present or future — is found. This is the fundamental difference that separates an *Ism* from a *Fi'l*.

Name of what	Examples
The name of a person	زَيْدٌ ، فَاطِمَةُ
The name of a thing	كِتَابٌ ، قَلَمٌ
The name of a place	مَدْرَسَةٌ ، مَسْجِدٌ

Name of what	Examples
The name of an action	نَصَرَ (helping) ، ضَرَبَ (striking)

Worth noting: The name of an action (such as striking, helping) is an *Ism*, whereas performing the action (he struck, he helped) is a *Fi'l*. The basis of the distinction is that tense is absent in the name of an action but present in a *Fi'l*.

3. What falls under the Ism in Arabic

The scope of the *Ism* in Arabic grammar is far wider than the English noun. Besides names, pronouns and all adjectives also fall under the *Ism*.

3.1 Ism ud Dameer

An *Ism ud Dameer* is a word used in place of an *Ism Dhahir*, that is, an openly stated noun such as Muhammad or book. When a name is not repeated again and again but replaced by a short word, that word is an *Ism ud Dameer*, as in هُوَ ، هُمَا ، أَنْتُمَا.

3.2 Sifah

A word that states the good or bad quality of an *Ism* is called a *Sifah* — in English, an adjective: a word that describes a noun or a pronoun. In Arabic a *Sifah* too is a kind of *Ism*.

Ordinary adjectives

Such as صَالِحَةٌ (righteous) and صَادِقٌ (truthful).

Colours

In both Arabic grammar and English, the names of colours count as adjectives. In Arabic, colours are also *Mudhakkar* and *Mu'annath*, so each colour has two separate words.

Colour	Mudhakkar	Mu'annath
black	أَسْوَدٌ	سَوْدَاءٌ
white	أَبْيَضٌ	بَيْضَاءٌ
red	أَحْمَرٌ	حُمْرَاءٌ
blue	أَزْرَقٌ	زَرْقَاءٌ
green	أَخْضَرٌ	خَضْرَاءٌ

Colour	Mudhakkar	Mu'annath
yellow	أَصْفَر	صَفْرَاء

Ism ul Fa'il and Ism ul Maf'ul

Ism ul Fa'il means the one who performs the action, as in مُعَلِّم ، عَابِد ، سَاجِد. *Ism ul Maf'ul* means the one upon whom the action is performed, as in مُعَلَّم ، مَعْبُود ، مَسْجُود.

How to tell them apart: Where a word begins with a meem carrying a *dammah*, the zabar and zer inside it are decisive. A word carrying a zer is the *Ism ul Fa'il*, the doer; a word carrying a zabar is the *Ism ul Maf'ul*, the one acted upon. So مُعَلِّم is one who teaches, and مُعَلَّم is one who is being taught.

Ism ul Mubalaghah

Ism ul Mubalaghah denotes one who performs an action a great deal, as in سَجَّاد (one who prostrates much) and تَوَّاب (one who accepts repentance abundantly).

Ism ut Tafdeel

When two things or two persons are compared in Arabic, or the highest degree of a quality is to be expressed, the word used is called an *Ism ut Tafdeel*. It generally comes on the pattern أَفْعَلُ, as أَحْسَن ، أَكْبَر.

- For comparison: عَلِيٌّ أَكْبَرُ مِنْ أَحْمَدَ (Ali is older than Ahmad)
- For the highest degree: هَذَا الْكِتَابُ أَحْسَنُ كِتَابٍ (this book is the best book)

Degree	English	Arabic
ordinary adjective	Big	كَبِير
comparative	Bigger	أَكْبَر
superlative	Biggest	أَكْبَر

An important difference: English uses two separate words for the comparative and the superlative (bigger and biggest), whereas Arabic uses the single word أَكْبَر for both. The

meaning is settled by the construction: if **مِنْ** follows, comparison is meant; if there is **idafah**, the highest degree is meant.

Sifah Mushabbahah

In Arabic a **Sifah Mushabbahah** is a quality that expresses an innate, permanent or lasting state — a description that is not temporary but always attached to the thing. Examples are **جَمِيلٌ** (beautiful), **كَبِيرٌ** (big), **طَوِيلٌ** (tall) and **قَوِيٌّ** (strong).

Nouns built from one root

How all these forms grow from a single root is best seen through the root **ع ل م**:

Type	Word and meaning
Masdar	عِلْمٌ — to know
Ism ul Fa'il	عَالِمٌ — one who knows
Ism ul Ma'ful	مَعْلُومٌ — that which is known
Ism ul Mubalaghah	عَالَمٌ / عَلَّامَةٌ — one who knows a very great deal
Ism ut Tafdeel	أَعْلَمٌ — one who knows more, or knows most
Sifah Mushabbahah	عَلِيمٌ — possessed of knowledge, as a lasting quality

4. Recognising an Ism in Arabic

The **Ism** has certain outward marks. Knowing them means that even when the meaning of an Arabic word is unknown, one can still tell from its form whether it is an **Ism**.

The three basic marks

- A round **ة** at the end of the word. The round **ة** occurs only at the end of an Arabic word and never at the end of a **Fi'l** or a **Harf**. So a word ending in a round **ة** is an **Ism**, even if its meaning is unknown.
- **Tanween** at the end of the word — two pesh, two zabar or two zer, as in **قَلَمٌ** ، **زَيْدًا** ، **كِتَابٌ**
- **Alif lam** at the beginning of the word, as in **الرَّجُلُ** ، **الْكِتَابُ**

If none of these outward marks is visible, the word is identified by its meaning.

Some further marks

- A *Harfun Nida* at the beginning, as in يَا يُوسُفُ
- A *Harful Jarr* at the beginning, as in فِي الْقَافِلَةِ
- The word being *Tathniyah* or *Jam'*, as in كِتَابَانِ ، مُسْلِمُونَ
- The word being *Mudaf* or *Mudaf Ilayh*, as in قَلَمٌ زَيْدٍ

An essential rule: Once *alif lam* enters an *Ism*, no *Tanween* can come at its end. The two marks cannot occur together. One says طَاوِلَةٌ (a table) or أَلْطَاوِلَةُ (the table), but never both at once.

Accordingly the *alif lam* that turns a *Nakirah* into a *Ma'rifah* is called *Harfut Ta'reef*, and the *Tanween* at the end is called *Harfut Tankeer*.

5. Further divisions of the Ism

The *Ism* is divided in three principal respects: by gender, by number, and by definiteness.

5.1 By gender: Mudhakkar and Mu'annath

- *Ism Mudhakkar* — an *Ism* in which no mark of *ta'neeth* is present, as in فَرَسٌ (a horse)
- *Ism Mu'annath* — an *Ism* in which a mark of *ta'neeth* is found, as in نَاقَةٌ (a she-camel)

There are three marks of *ta'neeth*:

- The round taa' ة, as in بَقَرَةٌ
- *Alif Maqsurah*, as in بُشْرَى
- *Alif Mamdudah*, as in سَوْدَاءُ

The *Mu'annath* divides again: one that is animate in contrast to a *Mudhakkar* is *Mu'annath Haqeeqi*, as in اِمْرَأَةٌ (a woman); and one that is not animate is *Mu'annath Lafzi*, as in ظُلْمَةٌ (darkness).

A special point: Some nouns carry no outward mark of *ta'neeth* at all, yet the Arabs use them as feminine. These are called *Mu'annath Sama'i*, such as أَرْضٌ (earth), شَمْسٌ (sun), نَارٌ (fire) and عَصَا (staff). They are known only by hearing and memorising.

5.2 By number: Wahid, Tathniyah and Jam'

Category	Definition	Example
Wahid	An Ism that denotes one individual	مُسْلِمٌ (one Muslim man)
Tathniyah	An Ism that denotes two individuals	مُسْلِمَانِ (two Muslim men)
Jam'	An Ism that denotes more than two individuals	مُسْلِمُونَ ، رِجَالٌ (Muslim men, men)

How the Tathniyah is formed: Adding تَانِ (an alif preceded by a fathah, with a kasrah-bearing nun) to the *Wahid* produces the *Tathniyah*, as does adding يَيْنِ (a silent yaa' preceded by a fathah, with a kasrah-bearing nun). So مُسْلِمٌ becomes مُسْلِمَانِ or مُسْلِمَيْنِ.

5.3 By definiteness: Ma'rifah and Nakirah

- *Ma'rifah* — an *Ism* that denotes something definite, as in زَيْدٌ ، عَلَامٌ زَيْدٍ ، هُوَ
- *Nakirah* — an *Ism* that denotes something indefinite, as in رَجُلٌ ، عَلَامٌ ، قَلَمٌ

The *Ism Ma'rifah* has seven categories:

Category	Definition	Example
Ism ud Dameer	An Ism denoting the speaker, the addressee or the absent one	أَنَا ، أَنْتَ ، هُوَ
Ism ul 'Alam	An Ism coined for one particular person, place or thing	خَالِدٌ ، مَكَّةُ
Ism ul Isharah	An Ism by which one points to something definite	هَذَا ، ذَلِكَ
Ism ul Mawsul	An Ism that becomes part of the speech by joining the clause after it	الَّذِي ، الَّتِي
Mu'arraaf bil Lam	An Ism beginning with the Lam ut Ta'reef	الْكِتَابُ ، الرَّجُلُ
Mu'arraaf bil Idafah	An Ism annexed to one of the five categories above	عَلَامُهُ
Mu'arraaf bin Nida	An Ism beginning with a Harf un Nida	يَا رَجُلُ

The *Ism Nakirah* also has two categories. A *Nakirah* made specific by some means of specification is *Nakirah Makhsusah*, as in رَجُلٌ عَالِمٌ and طِفْلٌ رَجُلٍ. One not made specific by any means is *Nakirah Ghayr Makhsusah*, as in كِتَابٌ.

Summary

1. The literal meaning of Ism is name. The name of a person, thing, place, quality or action is an Ism.
2. In terminology, an Ism conveys its meaning without joining another Kalimah and contains no tense.
3. English has nine parts of speech; Arabic has only three — Ism, Fi'l and Harf.
4. In Arabic the Ism ud Dameer also falls under the Ism, as in هُوَ ، هُما ، أَنْتُمَا.
5. A Sifah is also a kind of Ism, and the names of colours count as adjectives too.
6. Colours in Arabic are Mudhakkar and Mu'annath, as in سَوْدَاءَ against أَسْوَدَ.
7. In a word beginning with a meem carrying a dammah, a zer marks the Ism ul Fa'il and a zabar the Ism ul Ma'ful.
8. Ism ul Mubalaghah denotes one who performs an action a great deal, as in تَوَّابٌ and سَجَّادٌ.
9. Ism ut Tafdeel serves both for comparison and for the highest degree, and generally comes on the pattern أَفْعُلْ.
10. Sifah Mushabbahah expresses a permanent or lasting state, as in طَوِيلٌ and جَمِيلٌ.
11. The three basic outward marks of an Ism are: a round ة at the end, Tanween at the end, and alif lam at the beginning.
12. Alif lam and Tanween cannot occur together. Alif lam is Harf ut Ta'reef and Tanween is Harf ut Tankeer.
13. By gender the Ism is Mudhakkar or Mu'annath. There are three marks of ta'neeth: the round ة, the Alif Maqsurah and the Alif Mamdudah.
14. By number the Ism divides into Wahid, Tathniyah and Jam'.
15. By definiteness the Ism is Ma'rifah or Nakirah, and the Ma'rifah has seven categories.

Exercise

1. Give the literal and terminological definitions of Ism, and state on what basis an Ism differs from a Fi'l.
2. Write two Arabic examples each for the name of a person, a thing, a place and an action.
3. Explain the difference between Ism ul Fa'il and Ism ul Ma'ful using مُعَلِّمٌ and مُعَلَّمٌ.
4. Write the Mu'annath forms of the following colours: أَسْوَدَ , أَبْيَضَ , أَحْمَرَ , أَزْرَقَ.
5. What is an Ism ut Tafdeel? Give one example for comparison and one for the highest degree.
6. From the root ع ل م , form the Masdar, Ism ul Fa'il, Ism ul Ma'ful, Ism ul Mubalaghah and Ism ut Tafdeel.
7. Write the three basic outward marks of an Ism, giving two examples of each.
8. What is the rule concerning alif lam and Tanween? Explain with an example.
9. Write all three marks of ta'neeth with examples.

10. Form the Tathniyah of the following: مُسْلِمٌ , كِتَابٌ , قَلَمٌ.

11. Define Ma'rifah and Nakirah, and name the seven categories of the Ma'rifah.

12. Separate the Ma'rifah from the Nakirah in the following: رَجُلٌ , الْكِتَابُ , هُوَ , قَلَمٌ , مَكَّةُ , غُلَامٌ زَيْدٌ.

سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ